PRABHJOT GILL



STRIKING A RAW NERVE *Satluj* being screened at a gurdwara near Gurdaspur, Jul. 8; (left) CM Bhagwant Mann

The challenge for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is different. Since parting ways with the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), it has sought to expand beyond its traditional urban base but still lacks a statewide narrative that resonates in rural Punjab. Party leaders believe the debate around the film could consolidate Hindu voters and moderate Sikhs who feel the victims of militant violence have been sidelined. Some experts, however, say those voters could just as easily gravitate towards the Congress, which has long occupied the moderate centre.

Punjab is seeing two competing narratives: one seeks justice for alleged state excesses, the other for victims of militancy

For the SAD, *Satluj* is both an opportunity and an awkward reminder of its own decline. Since the 2015 sacrilege controversy and the police firing under the Parkash Singh Badal government, the party has steadily lost panthic credibility, culminating in a disastrous 2024 Lok Sabha election. Backing the film could help it reconnect with parts of its traditional panthic base.

Yet both SAD and AAP leaders privately worry that younger panthic voters may gravitate towards hardliners rather than the old Akali leadership. The 2024 election offered a glimpse of that shift, with radical figures such as Amritpal Singh winning Khadoor Sahib and Sarabjeet Singh Khalsa taking Faridkot, while other hardline candidates also cut into the traditional parties' vote base.

Whatever one makes of the film, its political impact is unmistakable. Punjab is witnessing two competing mobilisations. One seeks recognition for the victims of alleged state excesses; the other insists that the brutality of militancy cannot be pushed to the margins of public memory. Both are rooted in lived experience, and both are now competing for the same political space as the state heads to the polls. ■

own hardline politics and the unbridled violence unleashed by the very terrorists he stood on the side of.

Making Peace with History

The surprise release of *Satluj*, just six to seven months ahead of the assembly polls likely to be held in early 2027, has every political party in Punjab racing to gain advantage of the controversy (see *Political Flashpoint*). Both the Aam Aadmi Party government and the Congress have criticised New Delhi for removing the film hours after its OTT release, and have supported private screenings across Punjab. But the politics aside, many former bureaucrats and police officers in Punjab warn that a one-sided retelling of events could potentially provoke a fresh wave of fundamentalism among young Sikhs—born in the past 31 years, with no lived experience of Punjab's deadly decade. They could easily be triggered or swayed by the film's narrative.

As former Punjab chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh told *The Tribune*, "There is no point in running away from history. But that does not mean that history should end up polarising the present. We need to own our past and remember it to the extent where we do not repeat those mistakes." What Punjab needs now is not fear and retribution, but the harder work of closure—a reckoning honest enough to exorcise the ghosts of its darkest decade, rather than simply reawaken them. ■

— with inputs by Suhani Singh